

Department of Psychology and Cognitive Sciences

UG Handbook



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Introduction

Cognitive science and psychology both study the mind and mental processes, but they differ in their scope and approach. Psychology, which has a long history, studies the mind and behavior broadly, covering emotions, development, and social aspects. Cognitive Science, a relatively recent modern field, is an interdisciplinary field focused on how information is processed by the mind, brain, and machines, integrating psychology with computer science, linguistics, neuroscience, and philosophy.

The undergraduate program at Ashoka blends these two approaches and thus advances the theoretical understanding and practical application of how humans think, learn and behave and also provides avenues for students to pursue their personal passion. We seek to prepare a new breed of psychologists and cognitive scientists suitably trained and equipped to understand the 'entire' spectrum of human thought, perception and behaviour to serve modern society.

By integrating teaching with research the department is committed to promoting human well-being by:

1. offering well-grounded, high quality education to students through rigorous and experiential learning opportunities.
2. establishing state-of-art research for advancing the science of human behaviour and enabling translation of this research into practice for dealing with real-world problems
3. supporting advocacy and awareness by sharing knowledge and expertise by collaborating both locally and globally with researchers and policy makers at large
4. creating a liberal arts approach and a critical thinking ethos in the sciences to advocate good t professional practice in psychological sciences
5. building interagency partnerships among state agencies and programs in health, education, and human services.

Link to Website: [Department of Psychology and Cognitive Sciences](#)

Department Faculty

Permanent Faculty:

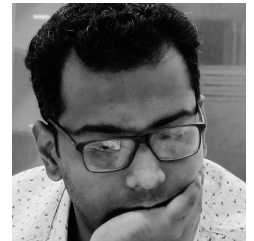
Bittu Kaveri Rajaraman

Bittu Kaveri Rajaraman is an Associate Professor of Biology and Psychology. He received a PhD from Harvard University in neuroscience, and was then a DST-Kothari postdoctoral fellow at the Center for Ecological Sciences, Indian Institute of Science, and then an INSPIRE Faculty Fellow at the Central University of Hyderabad. He works on the evolution of neural and behavioural systems of communication, the neuroethology of temporal pattern recognition in insects, and quantitative and economic cognition more broadly in zebrafish, dogs and humans.



Dipanjn Ray

Dipanjn was trained as a physician-physiologist. In his doctoral thesis, he developed a novel method to (re)construct 3D Vectorcariograms from 2D Electrocardiograms and established its clinical translatability. In his postdoc, he shifted from the cardiac signals to the most complex biological system of all: the human brain. Using functional MRI and brain connectivity analysis he provided insights into the neural processing of visual stimuli. In his second postdoc, he employed magnetoencephalography to examine how the human brain perceives statistical regularities in the environment. In recent times, his research has focused on mental health and mental health conditions including depression and anxiety. When he is not getting bogged down with debugging his codes, or hiking in the Himalayas, or communicating with the dead through reading...you can find him.....thinking!



Krishna Melnattur

Krishna Melnattur joined Ashoka as an Assistant Professor in August 2021. Prior to this he was a Staff Scientist in the Department of Neuroscience, Washington University School of Medicine, St Louis. He obtained a PhD in 2008 from the University of Massachusetts, Amherst and was a postdoctoral fellow at the National Institutes of Health, Bethesda. Krishna is interested in understanding how brains generate adaptive behaviours. To get at these questions, his lab uses a variety of techniques including genetics, circuit tracing tools, physiology and behavioural measurements. His current interests are in studying sleep on the fly *Drosophila*. His work speaks to two aspects of sleep – that sleep is plastic i.e. modifiable by environmental changes, and in turn supports brain plasticity and learning.



Mary Jane Arneaud

Mary Jane Arneaud received her BSc in Psychology, with first class honours, and earned her PhD in Psychology from The University of the West Indies – St. Augustine Campus. She conducted research as a Post-Doctoral Associate for two years at New York University Abu Dhabi and taught for one year as an Assistant Professor at Heriot-Watt University Dubai. She joined the faculty at Ashoka University as a tenure-track Assistant Professor in 2024. She teaches Cross-Cultural Psychology and Organisational Psychology in the undergraduate programme in psychology. Her research interests are primarily in the relations among developing a sense of ethnic group belonging (ethnic identity), psychological functioning (psychological wellbeing), and functioning in society (social wellbeing). She has studied these relations across young adults in Fiji and Trinidad and Tobago.



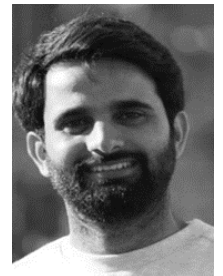
Nandini Chatterjee Singh

Nandini C. Singh is the Head of the Department for Psychology. She is a leading cognitive neuroscientist and science-policy education researcher. She has an established track record of combining innovative thinking with scientific evidence and research to develop, design and implement original solutions. She also collaborates with civil society, social institutions, policy makers and government bodies to translate research from the laboratory to the real world. A compassionate leader, she values empathy, evidence, inclusion and attention to detail.



Naseer Bhat

Naseer Bhat is a dedicated mental health researcher and clinical psychologist specializing in adolescent development and psychopathology. His research focuses on understanding adolescent risk-taking behaviors and synthesizing evidence in mental health. He also develops and validates psychological questionnaires to enhance research methodology. Dr. Bhat teaches courses on adolescent development, clinical psychology, and research methods, aiming to inspire and equip students to address mental health issues. His work bridges research and practice, aiming to improve mental health outcomes for adolescents and communities.



Pratishtha Petwal

Pratishtha Petwal is an Assistant Professor of Psychology at Ashoka University. She is a Clinical Psychologist and Mental Health Researcher with an MPhil and Ph.D. in Clinical Psychology from the National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences (NIMHANS), Bengaluru. She completed her B.A.(Hons.) and Masters in Psychology from the University of Delhi.



Her doctoral research focused on evaluating the efficacy of Rumination-Focused Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (RFCBT) for individuals with anxiety and depression. Her broader research interests include youth mental health, psychotherapy training, and the development of culturally

adapted interventions. In this context, she has studied cognitive-behavioral mechanisms underlying anxiety and depression, with particular attention to transdiagnostic factors such as rumination, perfectionism, procrastination, self-compassion, and emotion regulation.

Robin Sharma

Robin Sharma is a Learning Scientist and creator of theory-based, digital learning environments (DLEs). He has a B.Sc. (H) in Math, an M.Sc. in Math Education, and a Ph.D. in Learning Sciences. Currently, he is applying models of mathematical cognition to create an AI-driven, game-based, learning application for early numeracy. His research has focused on evaluating the effect of “narrative” as an instructional feature in math games, building interactive, game-based curriculum guides for teachers, and game-based courses for children. He has over seven years of experience in this space working for international non-profits (UNESCO) and the video-game industry (Ubisoft Inc.). His research has been supported by the International Doctoral Research Award from Universities Canada, the Doctoral Fellowship from the Government of Quebec, and a range of other competitive grants and scholarships.



Simantini Ghosh

Simantini (Simi) Ghosh conducts research on Gender and Mental health. She focuses on gender based violence and studies traumatic stress following sustained exposure to gender based violence and intergenerational transmission of violence and abuse. She is also interested in exploring the molecular neurobiology of stress in vivo. Her background has evolved from neuroscience to psychology. She studied neurodegeneration and neuroinflammation, traumatic brain injury and chronic and acute traumatic stress in the past. She earned a PhD in Neurobiology and Anatomy at the University of Rochester, NY and pursued her postdoctoral fellowship in Neurology at the Washington University School of Medicine in Saint Louis, MO prior to joining Ashoka.



Supriya Ray

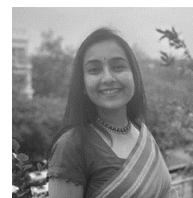
Supriya Ray is an Associate Professor of Psychology. He earned a Ph.D. in Neuroscience from National Brain Research Centre (India), after receiving an M.Tech. in Computer Sc. and Eng. from Calcutta University. He obtained his post-doctoral training in the USA at Vanderbilt University, The Smith-Kettlewell Eye Research Institute, and the State University of New York. Prior to joining Ashoka University, he was affiliated with Allahabad University as an Assistant Professor and an Intermediate Fellow of The Wellcome Trust DBT India Alliance. He is interested in understanding the neural mechanisms of action, attention, perceptual decision-making, and executive control. To this end, he uses different complementary techniques, like oculomotor behaviour, electrophysiology, psychophysics, pupillometry and simulation of computational models.



Visiting Faculty

Annie Baxi

Annie Baxi is currently an Assistant Professor at the Department of Psychology, Jesus and Mary College, University of Delhi. Her doctoral work is titled – “Exploring Discourses around Normalcy and Madness in Women’s Lives: A Study of Contemporary Indian Society”. In this research, she has studied a range of women groups and highlights the ways in which macro social processes shape and are shaped by individual subjectivities in the quest for normalcy and how madness can also be a manner of recovery and authentic living. She is also a practising psychotherapist and used a blend of psychodynamic and phenomenological approaches. Her current research includes analysing states of mental and physical illness from a systemic perspective where she is trying to articulate the need for reflexive processes and strategies on the part of the clinician.



Bhaskar Malu

Bhismadev Chakrabarti

Bhismadev Chakrabarti is a Professor of Neuroscience and Mental Health and Research Director of the Centre for Autism at the University of Reading, UK. After a first degree in Chemistry at St.Stephen’s College, India, he went to Trinity College, Cambridge, where he completed his Ph.D. in affective neuroscience. His research focuses on the core processes underlying human social behaviour, and individual differences therein. His lab uses a range of techniques to measure behaviour, autonomic, and neural activity. In parallel to his lab-based work, Prof Chakrabarti has been developing tools for neurodevelopmental assessments in low-resource settings that can be administered by non-specialists using mobile devices. His research is funded by grants from the Medical Research Council UK, Leverhulme Trust, British Council, and the European Research Council. In recognition of his contributions, he was awarded the Philip Leverhulme Prize in Psychology, and elected to the fellowship of the Young Academy of Europe.



Lee D. Cranberg

Lee D. Cranberg is a senior neurologist and former Harvard Medical School faculty member with more than four decades of clinical, academic, and teaching experience. He specializes in behavioral neurology, dementia, aphasia, and traumatic brain injury. An active educator and international lecturer, he has taught medical students and residents and delivered invited presentations across the United States and abroad, including in India and Central America. His research and publications span cognitive neurology, patient safety, and medical ethics. Recognized as a Boston Magazine Top Doctor in Neurology, Dr. Cranberg is known for combining rigorous scientific expertise with compassionate patient care. In addition to his academic and clinical career, he is a highly experienced medical-legal expert, having evaluated more than 250 cases and provided testimony in over 50 depositions and 25 trials involving personal injury, medical malpractice, and criminal proceedings.



Poonam Yadav

Poonam Yadav is a psychologist with academic training in organizational behavior, social psychology, and applied psychological sciences. She holds a PhD in psychology from Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. She completed her bachelor's and master's degrees in psychology from the University of Delhi, where she consistently ranked among the top students. She stood first in North Campus during the second year of her undergraduate program and secured the highest marks in the M.A. (Final) as well as in the combined M.A. (Previous and Final) examinations in the Department of Psychology, University of Delhi. During her undergraduate years, she received multiple academic distinctions for subject-wise and year-wise top scores.



Shitika Chowdhary

Shitika Chowdhary is a social and cultural psychologist who works in the areas of moral education, pedagogy, and multilingual education. She completed her PhD from Jawaharlal Nehru University where she worked on Moral Discourses in schools. She worked on a collaborative project between JNU and Cambridge University, funded by ESRC, United Kingdom, on Multilingualism and Multiliteracy. She was a part of the National Multilingual Research Consortium (NMRC), JNU where she worked on projects supported by Room to Read, USAID, and Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, MHRD. She has previously taught at Christ University, Bangalore.



Sneh Kapoor

Dr. Sneh specializes in clinical disorders (such as anxiety, depression, OCD, phobias) as well as emotional and behavioural challenges. In addition to these, she works primarily with young adults and adults across a range of concerns, which may include stress, academic difficulties, interpersonal concerns, professional challenges etc. Her practice centres around values of social justice, social inclusion and intersectionality, and employs an eclectic approach using CBT, supportive work, systemic and relational work. She did her PhD in Clinical Psychology from AIIMS New Delhi and has 13 years of practice experience. Her field of expertise is Anxiety, depression, OCD, phobias, lifestyle concerns (stress, academic difficulties, problems with motivation, etc.), and relationship concerns.



Soumya Madabhushi

Soumya Madabhushi is a psychologist (licensed in PA, USA) with over 15 years of experience providing different modalities of psychotherapy, mental health consulting, and training. She is driven by her passion to apply psychology toward healing individuals as well as communities. Toward this end she has founded the organisation Amaani Wellness Enterprise with the mission to help individuals, families, communities, and organisations, heal, grow, and thrive. Soumya obtained a Master's degree in Clinical Psychology from Pittsburg State University, then a PhD in Counseling Psychology



from University of Nebraska-Lincoln. She also completed a two-year intensive Psychodynamic Psychotherapy program through the Psychoanalytic Center of Philadelphia. She worked at CAPS at University of Pennsylvania for 8 years as a staff psychologist and outreach training coordinator. Outside of work she loves to work out and sing.

Courses

The Department offers a range of courses structured around three tiers: Fundamental Courses, Core Domain Courses, and Electives. These courses give students both the breadth of the discipline and sufficient depth for students who wish to have a more narrow specialisation within a domain. Note that some courses have prerequisites (courses that must be taken before enrolling in a particular course); co-requisites (courses that must be taken concurrently); and preclusions (courses that have sufficiently similar emphasis and must not be taken together with that course). Most courses are worth 4 credits (unless otherwise stated), and the workload for each 4-credit course is about 10 hours per week.

Do note that prerequisites, co-requisites and preclusions are subject to change each time a course is offered. Students should routinely check course descriptions during registration and departmental communication about the same prior to making concrete course trajectories.

Course Levels and Pre-Requisites

The 1000-Level course (PSY-1001: Introduction to Psychology) is the Gateway Course and is typically prerequisite for taking higher level courses. It is strongly recommended that students take the gateway course and SRM-I (PSY-2001) as soon as possible. Beyond this, the department does not impose a sequence in which to take core courses. Note though that some courses have prerequisites (courses that must be taken before enrolling in a particular course); co-requisites (courses that must be taken concurrently, that complement each other's knowledge base if taken together); and preclusions (courses that have sufficiently similar emphasis and must not be taken together with that course). Often, elective courses will have a gateway course, one or more statistics courses and one core domain course as prerequisites. **Only 'Statistics for Economics' (ECO-1400) is a valid substitute for SRM-I (PSY-2001).**

The department offers all required courses every semester. Therefore, currently there will be no waivers for any prerequisites for any core course. Prerequisites cannot be converted to co-requisites. If you have an incomplete grade that is a prerequisite for a core course, please reach out to the UG coordinator with a breakdown of all existing grade components for that course and a tentative date by which the incomplete will be converted to a grade from the course professor.

Note that the first digit of the course code specifies whether the course is at an introductory level to be taken in the second or third semester (1000), a core course level to be taken in the third or fourth semester (2000), a higher level elective (3000), a course specifically envisioned for fourth year UG students (4000), or a specific graduate level course (6000). Some courses that are listed both at undergraduate and graduate level cover the same material but offer advanced assignments for graduate

students. While the third and fourth digits just track and group multiple courses in various subdomains, the second digit of the course code specifies the overall course domain:

0 Introduction, Statistics or Methodology domain

1 Bio domain

2 Cognitive domain

3 Developmental domain

4 Clinical domain

5 Social domain

6 Interdisciplinary Electives

7 Instructional electives

8 Methodology electives

9 Lab or research module

Curriculum Structure

The structure of the psychology curriculum resembles a pyramid, with Gateway Courses (Introduction to Psychology, Statistics and Research Methodology I) at the lowest tier, Core Domains (Statistics and Research Methodology II, Biological Psychology, Cognitive Psychology, Developmental Psychology, Clinical Psychology, and Social Psychology) in the middle-tier, and Electives at the top-tier. Students are encouraged to complete their Gateway Courses and Core Domains as early as possible because many of these are prerequisites for upper-level electives.

Major Requirements (4-year BSc)

18 courses (8 Req + 10 Elec)

Minor Requirements

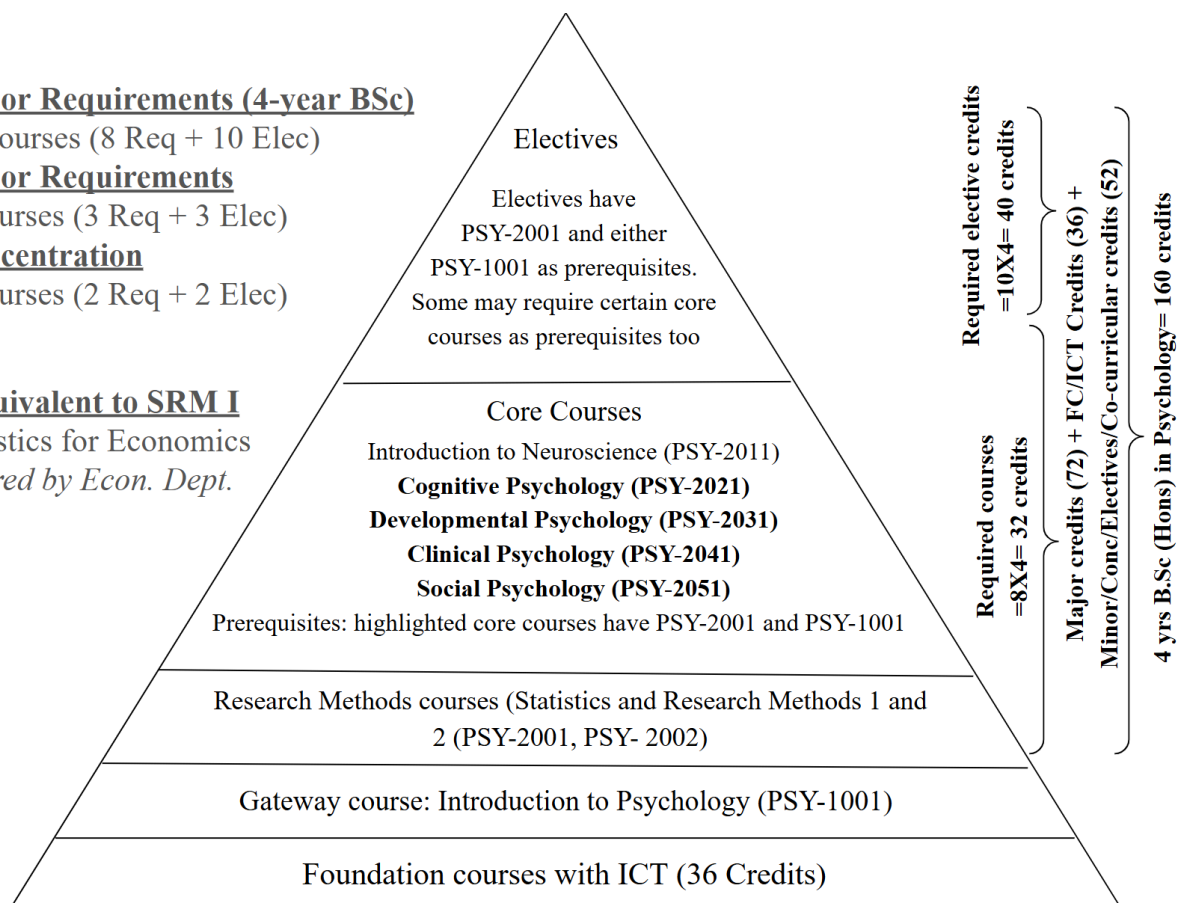
6 courses (3 Req + 3 Elec)

Concentration

4 courses (2 Req + 2 Elec)

***Equivalent to SRM I**

Statistics for Economics

Offered by Econ. Dept.

New credit distributions for FCs, co-curricular courses and internships (years 3,4)

S. No.	Type of Courses	Three-year B.A./B.Sc. (Hons.)		Four-year B.A./B.Sc. (Hons.)		Four-year B.A./B.Sc. (Hons. with Research)	
		Type A	Type B	Type A	Type B	Type A	Type B
1	Foundation Courses	36	36	36	36	36	36
2	Co-Curricular Courses	4	4	4	4	4	4
3	Internship	2	2	2	2	2	2
4	Major Courses** (Minimum Credits)	52	60	72	80	72	80
5	Research	None	None	None	None	12	12
6	Other Courses ***	26	18	46	38	34	26
	Total Credits	120	120	160	160	160	160

The 4 year program is now the default, with an option to leave at the end of the third year. In the 4th year, the thesis track will need 12 credits over and above the 20 credits worth of MM courses in PSY, and 2 other non major courses.

Major in Psychology (TYPE A)

4-year B.Sc (Hons) with Research Program: 160 credits

36 credits over and above year 3

- Major credits in 4th year = Minimum 20 (5 PSY courses)*
- Thesis research = 4+8 =12 credits
- Internships= 2 credits (Only if not taken previously)
- Non major credits= 8 (Second major/ Minors/Concentrations etc)

4-year B.Sc (Hons) Program: 160 credits

A total of 40 credits over and above year 3

- Major credits in 4th year = Minimum 20 (5 PSY courses)*
- Internships= 2 credits (Only if not taken previously)
- Non major credits= 20 (Second major/ Minors/Concentrations etc)

**Courses if major req. are not met by end of year 3*

3-year B.Sc (Hons) Program: 120 credits

- Major credits = Minimum 52 (13 courses, see below)
- Non Major credits = 62 (36 Credits from 9 Foundation courses, 26 from other courses for Minors/Concentrations etc.)
- Co-curricular courses = 4 credits
- Internship = 2 credits

Courses we offer:

Gateway courses

PSY-1001 Introduction to Psychology

This course introduces psychology as an empirical, behavioural science. It considers the approaches different psychologists take to describe and explain behaviour. It covers a broad range of topics, including how animals learn, how personality develops and influences functioning, how the nervous system is structured and how knowledge of neuroscience may inform a neurodiverse understanding of mental variation, how people acquire, remember and process information, how psychopathology is diagnosed and treated, how children and adults develop, and how people behave in groups and think

about social environments. The focus of the course is on building the skills necessary to think critically and scientifically like a psychologist.

Prerequisites: None.

PSY-2001 Statistics & Research Methodology I

The primary focus of this course is mastering basic statistical concepts and reasoning. In the process, students will learn characteristics of different types of research, and how to think critically about statistics. The course also includes a practical component where students learn how to use statistical software to analyse existing datasets (secondary data analysis). Students are advised to take this course as soon as possible.

Prerequisites: None.

Preclusion: Statistics for Economics (Economics Department).

PSY-2002 Statistics & Research Methodology II

The primary focus of this course is on mastering different research methods and research designs, with more in-depth learning of statistical thinking. Students will embark on an empirical project where they will devise testable hypotheses, design a study to collect primary data, and then analyse, interpret, and present their findings. Students are advised to take this course as soon as possible.

Prerequisites: Statistics & Research Methodology I (Psychology Dept), or Statistics for Economics (Economics Dept),

Core courses

PSY-2011/ BIO-2103 Introduction to Neuroscience

This course provides an introduction to the relationship between the brain and behaviour. The focus will be on understanding how behaviour is produced by the brain. The course seeks to answer key questions about how neurons produce behaviour, how the human brain is organised and how the brain processes information.

Prerequisites: None

PSY-2021 Cognitive Psychology

Cognitive psychology, a subtopic within the field of psychology, is the scientific study of how people think, perceive, remember, reason, understand, and language. It examines how people process information and how that information leads to their responses. The specific emphasis is given on current models in cognitive psychology from a theoretical perspective as well as the research methods that allow us to make accurate inferences about the workings of the mind. Topics will include perception, attention, memory, imagery, language, comprehension, problem solving, and decision-making.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology & SRM1

PSY-2031 Developmental Psychology

This course reviews the fundamentals of developmental psychology, a field of study devoted to understanding both the continuity and change that makes up human growth throughout the lifespan. Students will gain exposure to a range of developmental psychology theories and learn how these are applied to developmental milestones across life-stages.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology & SRM1

PSY-2041 Clinical Psychology

This module introduces the most common self reported mental health problems such as anxiety, depression, eating disorders, behavioural problems, attention deficits, learning disabilities, schizophrenia, personality disorders, sexual adjustment, substance abuse, suicide, and dementia. The course focuses on developing a holistic and nuanced understanding of these mental health issues, with a critical understanding of diagnosis and pathology.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology AND SRM1

PSY-2051 Social Psychology

This course explores the scientific nature of social influence and interaction, covering topics such as social judgement, self-concept, attitudes, conformity, prejudice, and interpersonal relationships. We will also pay particular attention to the use of empirical evidence from which we build theories of social behaviour.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology AND SRM1

Some Elective Courses Offered in Past Years

PSY-3011 Advanced Topics in Neuroscience

This course allows students to explore the neural processes that produce various aspects of cognition and behavior, such as sensation, motor control, communication, creativity, navigation, decision making, learning and memory. The goal of this class is for students to explore various topics in neuroscience that give one a sense of the possible framework of computation through electrical signaling by wet, messy, living systems. We discuss the strengths and limitations of various methods by which inferences about the neural basis of cognition are made, by reading and evaluating primary scientific material.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Neuroscience

PSY-3012 Evolutionary Cognition

What is cognition? How has it evolved? What cognitive abilities do animals possess? Are they similar to those found in humans? What narratives about the evolution of behaviour are scientifically grounded? This course provides a critical review of various theories of the evolution of cognition and training on how to review the standards of evidence behind various claims.

Prerequisites: None, but students are advised to have taken Introduction to Neuroscience

PSY-3024 Cognition in Action

This course focuses on how we plan, control and execute an action categorised to be reflexive, patterned, voluntary and autonomic. The neuroscience of the motor system and cognitive processes underlying a large repertoire of actions we perform on a day-to-day basis, from elementary activity like walking to complicated and time-critical action like key-boarding or catching ball in cricket game, and atypical movement behaviours in pathological conditions are discussed in this course.

PSY-3026 Empirical Basis of Cognition

This course uses experimental evidence to connect the concepts of mind, brain, and behaviour. Cognitive and neural mechanisms of behaviour are studied by examining sensory processes – both visual perception and audition – attention, learning and memory, higher cognition, and language. This is followed by an introduction to atypical psychology - autism, schizophrenia, OCD, and eating disorders. Mind and behaviour are studied at different levels of evidence, from single neurons, population neural activity, and fMRI activations to behavioural studies. A special emphasis is placed on understanding experimental methodology, design, and analysis.

PSY-3029 Adolescent Development and Psychopathology

Adolescent Development and Psychopathology offers an in-depth exploration of developmental changes (biological, psychological, emotional, and social) that occur during the phase of adolescence. Equally, this course offers a comprehensive study of various psychopathologies that can emerge during this critical developmental stage. The course is designed to provide undergraduate students with a strong foundational understanding of both typical and atypical adolescent development and prepare them for advanced level courses and research pursuits in the field of adolescent development and psychopathology.

PSY-3025 Introductory Python for Experimental Psychologists

This course is designed as an undergraduate course for students who are seeking to build their expertise in experimental psychology with an emphasis on using Python. It will provide an introduction to the Python programming language, focusing on how it can be utilized for the design and analysis of psychology experiments. Students will learn how to use the PsychoPy package for creating experiments and the matplotlib library for data visualization, along with other relevant Python libraries. The current course aims to introduce the fundamentals of Python programming while also helping students gain confidence when designing experiments. The course was designed keeping in mind the students who have minimal or no coding experience but who are interested to learn to program.

PSY-3042 Introduction to Counseling Psychology

This course is designed to provide the student with an overview of counseling psychology as a profession. It will introduce the student to the scientist/practitioner model, and in so doing, define the subject matter of counseling psychology, the target population the counseling psychologist seeks to serve, and the technical tools professional counselors use during their practice.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology/Thinking like a psychologist ; Statistics & Research Methodology I; Clinical Psychology

PSY-3043 Psychoactive Drugs

This course, with a focus on psychoactive drugs, explores the neurotransmitter systems underlying abnormal psychology and behavior and how modern generation drugs alter neurotransmitter balance to putatively restore functionality and behavior. The course is designed to introduce pharmacological concepts for students without prior exposure to college level biology and build upon the knowledge from clinical psychology to explore psychopharmacology-based treatment approaches.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Neuroscience; Clinical Psychology; Statistics & Research Methodology II

PSY-3045 Violence as a Human Behaviour

This course brings in materials pertaining to violence and aggression across the disciplines of neuroscience, evolutionary biology, sociology, psychology and political science. The course will first try to break violence down to its neurobiological roots, and then rebuild it using perspectives from behavior, sociocultural patterns and aggression. We will examine mob violence, violent crimes, violence against women and children, violence against ethnic minorities and “legitimized” violence.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Neuroscience; Statistics & Research Methodology II

PSY-3048 Trauma, Recovery and Repair

The course will cover the neurobiology of trauma, psychological mechanisms and dysfunctions that underlie traumatic response. We will also discuss concepts related to the somatization of trauma. The second section of the course will cover the link between trauma and psychopathology- we will cover the genetics, epigenetics, and behavioral perspectives underlying this link and discuss how trauma affects behavior at an individual and collective level. We will further explore collective and intergenerational trauma perspectives. The third and final section of the course will focus on interventions and trauma-informed care, strengths and weaknesses, pitfalls and planning of future interventions.

PSY-3049 Psychological Understanding of Trauma

The course will cover the neurobiology of trauma, psychological mechanisms and dysfunctions that underlie traumatic response. We will also discuss concepts related to the somatization of trauma. The second section of the course will cover the link between trauma and psychopathology- we will cover the genetics, epigenetics, and behavioral perspectives underlying this link and discuss how trauma affects behavior at an individual and collective level. We will further explore collective and intergenerational trauma perspectives. The third and final section of the course will focus on interventions and trauma-informed care, strengths and weaknesses, pitfalls and planning of future interventions. The instructor will use a flipped classroom in half the classes, where students will present papers, and the instructor will serve as a mediator. We will assume an intersectional lens when we analyze specific examples. The instructor will pick case studies from South Asian and Indian contexts in particular for students to appreciate how cross-cultural differences in norms and attitudes can have long-lasting effects on how trauma is experienced, addressed and processed.

PSY-3058 Psychology and Law

This course presents an interesting intersection and an extensive body of research that focuses on the application of psychological theories to the understanding of criminal behavior, court procedures and other socio-legal realities. This course will present a unique and critical approach to legal issues, rooted within a social-psychological approach with the intention to find answers to difficult questions that define the subject area of law, ethics, mental health, investigation and rehabilitation.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology, SRM II

PSY-3059 Group Processes and Intergroup Relations

Why do individuals identify with different groups and what motivates them to behave in extreme ways to uphold group goals? How are group differences in status and opportunity maintained and justified through generations? This course will answer these and similar questions by engaging with the various ways that groups interact and behave. We will examine how the individual relates to their social identity and how that identity shapes individual actions. The course will cover foundational and contemporary social-psychological theories on prejudice, stereotyping, identity, intergroup bias, intergroup conflict and leadership. Through active discussion and reflection with students the course will look at how intergroup

relations are being reshaped in a digital world and the significance of social identity in light of recent global events and movements.

Prerequisites: Social Psychology and SRM II

PSY-3061 Gender and Mental Health

This course focuses on the intersectionality between Gender and Mental health across various domains. We start with theoretical concepts of Gender formulations in psychology, the history of gender struggle and rights movements, methodology and ethical issues in gender psychology research, and proceed to explore mental health and well-being as well as gender trauma. Throughout, the instructor strives for a balance of introducing the class to literature that is cross-culturally pertinent.

Pre Requisite: SRM2, Clinical Psychology

PSY-3062 Psychology of Gender

This course will focus on the intersections between Gender and Psychology across various domains. We will start with theoretical concepts of Gender formulations in psychology, history of gender struggle and rights movements, methodology and ethical issues in gender psychology research, and proceed towards exploring other psychological variables in gender. Throughout, the instructor will strive for a balance of introducing the class to literature that is cross-culturally pertinent.

Prerequisite: SRM2, Social Psychology

PSY-3063/ ECO-3063 Behavioural Science and Public Policy

Policymakers are increasingly using behavioural science to address complex development challenges, such as improving education, promoting energy conservation, and empowering women. This course aims to teach students how to use behavioural science to solve social problems and introduce cutting-edge research in the field. Through lectures, games, and case studies, students will learn the fundamental principles of applied behavioural science and apply them for public policy and program implementation.

PSY-3064 Mental Health in a Digital Society

It is an interdisciplinary inquiry into the profound psychological and existential agonies characteristic of our digital age. We move beyond symptomology to investigate the root psychological, neuroscientific, philosophical, and systemic causes of widespread distress in a hyperconnected society. The course operates on a foundational premise: that deep understanding—the synthesis of knowledge across multiple frames—can itself be a form of liberation, even if it does not provide simple solutions.

PSY-3065 Organisational Psychology

The course examines concepts, theory, and research from psychology and related disciplines, to understand human behavior in organizational settings. Topics such as motivation, feelings, attitudes, and group dynamics are examined from both the perspective of the organizational members (e.g., employees) and the organization. The course has an applied emphasis and aims to prepare a student for entry and participation in any type of organization.

Prerequisite: Introduction to Psychology

PSY-3066 Cross Cultural Psychology

The course examines a range of topics at the intersection of culture and psychology. How culture influences the lives of people across the world, their feelings, thoughts, and behaviours, is explored to

better understand one another. Both cultures that are overrepresented and underrepresented in psychological research are covered.

Prerequisite: Introduction to Psychology

PSY-3082 Qualitative Research Methods

Although quantitative methods feature heavily in modern psychological research, qualitative data is also useful in many ways; sometimes it is even indispensable when studying certain phenomena. But qualitative research methodology is not just about asking people what their opinions or feelings are about a particular issue. This course trains students to extract information from qualitative data to yield psychological insights.

Prerequisites: Statistics and Research Methods II; completed at least 3 out of 5 core domains

PSY-3083 Psychology of Health and Illness

The paper is a blend of Critical and Cultural Health Psychology and intends to detail the various theoretical perspectives on health and illness and strategies that promote healing and wellbeing. Health is defined as ‘a way of being’ which is not limited by the absence of malfunction or disease but an experience that is grounded in one’s body and is shaped largely by individual and collective attributions around it. The designed course attempts to address questions like how do we identify and operationalise markers of a healthy living in a context? What are the various ways in which illness(es) can be experienced ? What is the symbiotic relationship of the individual reality and social processes in understanding health and illness?

PSY-4022 Gaming and Cognition

Digital gaming is the delivery of interactive learning and entertainment experiences delivered through interactive digital formats. Gaming or play is a powerful cognitive tool since it promotes and stimulates activities like attention, motivation, reward, creativity and memory and social interaction. Consequently, digital game design is influenced by an understanding of cognition. In recent years, research has shown that well-designed digital games can enhance cognitive abilities like attention, visuospatial skills, and working memory. This course will provide an introduction to cognitive processes that influence game mechanics and followed by an application of this to learning. We will reflect on a range of guiding questions critical to game design in the context of learning and training. The course will adopt an interactive teaching-learning methodology with a mix of lectures and hands-on activities.

PSY-4062 Subjective Well-Being: The Science of Happiness

Subjective well-being (SWB, often referred to as happiness) pertains to people's evaluations of their lives, encompassing both cognitive judgments, such as life satisfaction, and affective evaluations, including positive and negative feelings. People are said to have high SWB if satisfied with their lives and experience frequent positive and infrequent negative emotions. Understanding this concept can be very beneficial for leading a rewarding life in every sphere of an individual's life, both internal and external. It helps individuals identify what is important in leading a good and meaningful life. It helps them realize their inner potential and the strength of their psychological treasure to mitigate life circumstances, and how to develop the right approach to face and deal with adverse conditions. This is a reflection and evidence-based course that aims to equip students with strategies to optimize their SWB by reflecting on the learning from the science and applying it to their experiences.

PSY 4041 Helping Skills

This course focuses on effective helping skills. Students learn about the effectiveness of helping skills by (i) learning about the theory and research on helping skills and (ii) practicing helping skills with each other.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Counseling (or equivalent clinical psychology elective)

Independent Study Module

The Independent Study Module (ISM) allows students to delve more deeply into research, either assisting an instructor on a specific research agenda, or in some cases, charting their own research agenda. Students must seek out an instructor in the department and work out a concrete plan with the instructor before signing up for the course. Students may do only one ISM at level-3000.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology; Statistics and Research Methods I; with the consent of the instructor; subject to mutual interest between student and faculty

Advanced Independent Study Module

The Advanced Independent Study Module (ISM) is for UG4 students who are not doing an honors thesis, yet want further exposure beyond the initial PSY-3xxx ISM which they have already taken. Students must seek out an instructor in the department and work out a concrete plan with the instructor before signing up for the course.

Prerequisites: Introduction to Psychology; Statistics and Research Methods I and II; PSY-3xxx; subject to mutual interest between student and faculty

Requirements for 4 Year B.Sc (Hons) with Research

Major: Psychology		
Degree : 4 Years (Hons.) with Research		
Duration: 4 Years		
Major Credits: 84		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	32	All of the following Eight (08) : 1. Introduction to Psychology 2. Statistics and Research Methods I 3. Cognitive Psychology 4. Social Psychology 5. Developmental Psychology 6. Statistics and Research Methods II 7. Clinical Psychology 8. Introduction to Neuroscience
Electives Courses	40	Any elective course of 3000 Level or above, preferably offered by PSY department; these may include three courses offered by another department that is cross-listed with the PSY department, as well as up to two 4000 level advanced ISMs courses offered by permanent faculty member(s) of the PSY department in 4th year, one each semester.
Research	12	1. PSY-CP-4997 Thesis Proposal : 4 credits 2. PSY-CP-4998 Thesis: 8 credits
Total Major Credits	32+40+12 = 84	
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	3 (Up to 1 cross-listed elective in 4th year)	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	Up to two 4000 level Advanced ISMs in 4th year, one each semester, provided they have not taken any ISM earlier	
Remarks	For students who want to undertake a thesis research track, the recommendation in 4th year are as follows: 1. Two PSY electives (Can be the graduate writing workshop/ graduate research methods course) 2. Up to One cross-listed elective	

Teaching Assistantships (TA)	A maximum of two UGTAs (2 credits each) can count towards the major yielding a maximum of four credits for UGTAs. They are only allowed in third and fourth year.
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Note: A total of maximum 12 ISM credits shall be counted in the elective courses' credit category. Each ISM carries 4 credits.

Requirements for 4 Year B.Sc (Hons)

Major: Psychology		
Degree: 4 Years (Hons.)		
Duration: 4 Years		
Major Credits: 72		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	32	All of the following Eight (08) : 1. Introduction to Psychology 2. Statistics and Research Methods I 3. Cognitive Psychology 4. Social Psychology 5. Developmental Psychology 6. Statistics and Research Methods II 7. Clinical Psychology 8. Introduction to Neuroscience
Electives Courses	40	Any elective courses of 3000 Level or above, preferably offered by PSY department; these may include three courses offered by another department that is cross-listed with the PSY department, as well as up to two 4000 level advanced ISMs courses offered by permanent faculty member(s) of the PSY department in 4th year, one each semester.
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	3 (Up to 1 cross-listed elective in 4th year)	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	Up to two 4000 level Advanced ISMs in 4th year, one each semester, provided they have not taken any ISM earlier	
Remarks	For non-research track, the recommendation is to take 5 PSY courses in 4th year as follows: i) Up to 1 UGTAship (If UGTAship credits not already utilized in 3rd year ii) Up to 1 cross-listed elective iii) Up to two 4000 level Advanced ISMs, one each semester (check for any conflict with the internship policy)	
Teaching Assistantships (TA)	A maximum of two UGTAships (2 credits each) can count towards the major yielding a maximum of four credits for UGTAships. They are only allowed in third and fourth year.	

Note: A total of maximum 12 ISM credits shall be counted in the elective courses' credit category. Each ISM carries 4 credits.

Requirements for 3 Year B.Sc (Hons)

Major: Psychology		
Degree: 3 Years (Hons.)		
Duration: 3 Years		
Major Credits: 52		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	32	All of the following Eight (08): 1. Introduction to Psychology 2. Statistics and Research Methods I 3. Cognitive Psychology 4. Social Psychology 5. Developmental Psychology 6. Statistics and Research Methods II 7. Clinical Psychology 8. Introduction to Neuroscience
Elective Courses	20	Any elective courses of 3000 Level or above, preferably offered by PSY department; these may include two courses offered by another department that is cross-listed with the PSY department, as well as up to two 3000 level advanced ISMs courses offered by permanent faculty member(s) of the PSY department in 3rd year, one each semester
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	2	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	Up to two 3000 level ISM	
Remarks	1. UGTA ships in general are not recommended in 3rd year. 2. For all UGTA ships, preference will be given to 4th year applicants and a 3rd year UGTA can only be accepted in exceptional circumstances. 3. In case this happens, the student is required to send an email to the department manager within 4 weeks from the semester starting date, with their name, course name, course number and course instructor's name.	

Note: A total of maximum 8 ISM credits shall be counted in the elective courses' credit category. Each ISM carries 4 credits.

Requirements for Minor in Psychology and Cognitive Sciences

Minor: Psychology		
Duration : Applicable for both 3 Years & 4 Years		
Minor Credits: 24		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	12	All of the following Three (3) courses: 1. PSY-1001: Introduction to Psychology 2. PSY-2001: Statistics and Research Methods- I 3. PSY-2002: Statistics and Research Methods- II
Elective Courses	12	Students are to ensure they take at least one course from Group A and at least one course from Group B. Group A: 1. PSY-2011: Introduction to Neuroscience 2. PSY-2021: Cognitive Psychology Group B: 1. PSY-2031: Developmental Psychology 2. PSY-2041: Social Psychology 3. PSY-2051: Clinical Psychology Any one (1) PSY Elective :- The student may take 1 Elective course, worth 4 credits. This may include a course offered by another department that is cross-listed with the PSY department, as well as an ISM course offered by a permanent faculty member of the PSY department.
Total Credits	12 + 12 = 24	
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	1	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	4	
Remarks	-	

Note: Maximum 4 ISM credits shall be counted in the elective courses' credits category. Each ISM carries 4 credits.

Requirements for Concentration in Psychology and Cognitive Sciences

Concentration: Psychology		
Duration : Applicable for both 3 Years & 4 Years		
Concentration Credits: 16		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	8	All of the following Two (2) courses: 1. PSY-1001: Introduction to Psychology 2. PSY-2001: Statistics and Research Methods- I
Elective Courses	8	Any two (2) courses from the following: 1. PSY-2002: Statistics and Research Methods- II 2. PSY-2011: Introduction to Neuroscience 3. PSY-2021: Cognitive Psychology 4. PSY-2031: Developmental Psychology 5. PSY-2041: Social Psychology 6. PSY-2051: Clinical Psychology
Total Credits	8 + 8 = 16	
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	0	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	0	
Remarks	No ISMs are allowed	

Interdisciplinary Major in Psychology and Cognitive Sciences and Philosophy

Natural Dimensions of Synergy

As a discipline, Psychology evolved in a process that started in the mid-18th century in Germany, first as a subdomain of Philosophy. Its development as a discipline in its own right picked up steam in the 19th century, when through the work of Gustav Fechner and Wilhelm Wundt, first experimentally testable theories about the production of sensory experiences were constructed and first experimental labs were created. Psychology emerged as a separate discipline from Philosophy in 1879 with Wilhelm Wundt's establishment of the first psychological laboratory at the University of Leipzig, Germany.

Subsequently, Psychology began to be increasingly separated from Philosophy in the 20th century, a process facilitated also by the fact that it began to integrate in its conceptual framework developments from within other disciplines such as Computer Science and Biology. For quite some time, Psychology has been occupying a sort of middle position between the empirical sciences and the humanities and as such, work of influential psychologists such as, e.g., Sigmund Freud, Carl Jung, and William James did and still do serve as reference points for both psychological and philosophical theorizing. Currently, Psychology appears to be moving further towards establishing itself as a predominantly empirical science.

At Ashoka, too, Psychology undergraduate degrees have been re-classified from yielding a B.A. to yielding a B.Sc. And yet, it is also true not just as a matter of etymology—which marks Psychology as reasoned speech (λόγος) about the soul or spirit (ψυχή)—but conceptually as well, that the ties between Psychology and Philosophy are inseverable. Psychology, in its theoretical aspect, must draw on conceptions of the mind, the self, consciousness, cognition, perception, attention, recognition, emotion, affect, love and hate, to name just a few, each of which fall squarely within the realm of Philosophy. Moreover, there are many issues in the most advanced areas of psychological theorizing, or theorizing with psychological input—such as cognitive science, cognitive neuroscience and predictive coding approaches—that integrate aspects from both PSY and PHI.

The overlap between the two disciplines is thus significant and, in the case of Psychology, understanding what falls into this overlap is essential to understanding its subject matter. Philosophers have much to gain from becoming more familiar both with contemporary psychological theorizing and with empirical psychological work since the result of such work are frequently open to multiple interpretations and the question what inferences can be drawn from them results requires careful consideration that may in turn provide challenges or support for the conceptions that both psychologists and philosophers investigate. Psychologists, on the other hand, have much to gain by engaging with the philosophical conceptual foundations of their discipline and with western and eastern conceptions of mind and soul, and by making use of the formal and theoretical tools that Philosophy provides, e.g., via Logic or subdisciplines such as Philosophy of Science that concern themselves with the fundamental terms and assumptions that structure scientific activity.

Requirements for 4 Year B.Sc (Hons) with Research

Major: Psychology and Philosophy		
Degree : 4 Years (Hons.) with Research		
Duration: 4 Years		
Major Credits: 92		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	28	1. PHI-1000 -Introduction to Philosophy All of the following Three (3): 1. PSY-1001 - Introduction to Psychology 2. PSY-2001 - Statistics and Research Methods I 3. PSY-2002 - Statistics and Research Methods II Any Three (3) from the following Five (5): 1. PSY-2011 -Introduction to Neuroscience 2. PSY-2021 - Cognitive Psychology 3. PSY-2031 - Developmental Psychology 4. PSY-2041 - Clinical Psychology 5. PSY-2051 - Social Psychology
Electives Courses	52	Any Eight (8) PHI course from Code Range PHI: 1000 - 4999 Any Five (5) PSY course from Code Range: PSY: 3000 - 4999
Research	12	
Total Major Credits	28 + 52 + 12 = 92	
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	NA	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	2 ISMs courses are allowed	

Requirements for 4 Year B.Sc (Hons)

Major: Psychology and Philosophy		
Degree: 4 Years (Hons.)		
Duration: 4 Years		
Major Credits: 80		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	28	1. PHI-1000 -Introduction to Philosophy All of the following Three (3): 1. PSY-1001 - Introduction to Psychology 2. PSY-2001 - Statistics and Research Methods I 3. PSY-2002 - Statistics and Research Methods II Any Three (3) from the following Five (5): 1. PSY-2011 - Introduction to Neuroscience 2. PSY-2021 - Cognitive Psychology 3. PSY-2031 - Developmental Psychology 4. PSY-2041 - Clinical Psychology 5. PSY-2051 - Social Psychology
Electives Courses	52	Any Eight (8) PHI course from Code Range PHI: 1000 - 4999 Any Five (5) PSY course from Code Range: PSY: 3000 - 4999
Research	NA	
Total Major Credits	28 + 52 = 80	
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	NA	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	Up to two Advanced ISMs in Psychology	
Remarks	For students who do not want to undertake a thesis research track, the recommendation is to take up to 4 credits of elective courses from either psychology or philosophy	

Requirements for 3 Year B.Sc (Hons)

Major: Psychology and Philosophy		
Degree: 3 Years (Hons.)		
Duration: 3 Years		
Major Credits: 60		
Course Type	Credits	Courses
Required Courses	28	1. PHI-1000 -Introduction to Philosophy All of the following Three (3): 1. PSY-1001 -Introduction to Psychology 2. PSY-2001 - Statistics and Research Methods I 3. PSY-2002 - Statistics and Research Methods II Any Three (3) from the following Five (5): 1. PSY-2011 - Introduction to Neuroscience 2. PSY-2021 - Cognitive Psychology 3. PSY-2031 - Developmental Psychology 4. PSY-2041 - Clinical Psychology 5. PSY-2051 - Social Psychology
Elective Courses	32	Any Six (6) PHI course from Code Range PHI: 1000 - 4999 Any Two (2) PSY course from PSY-3000 level
Research	NA	
Total Major Credits	28 + 32 = 60	
Maximum Cross Listed Courses Allowed	NA	
Maximum ISM credits allowed	NA	

Undergraduate Exchange Programs/ Summer Abroad Programs:

Psychology majors intending to go for a summer abroad or semester-long exchange programmes should be aware that most upper-level psychology modules have prerequisites, which may not be explicitly mentioned in the host universities' webpages.

The departmental recommendation is to apply for a semester abroad for students in year 3, that is when students can get the maximum benefit from additional electives beyond the scope of Ashoka offerings.

The department will not waive any mandatory coursework requirement, including core courses.

Please do familiarize that you fulfill the departmental criteria for the approval (listed below)

- If Year 1: Clear Gateway or equivalent
- If Year 2: Must clear ALL Core Domain courses
- If Year 3: Electives that can be transferable

For any approval requests the AMS department will ask for a copy of the syllabus for each course applied to.

- To upload, navigate to the folder [Semester/Summer Abroad Applications](#)
- Find the folder for semester you want to apply for or make a new one if not there already
- Find your institute's folder or make one if the university you are applying for does not have a demarcated folder yet
- Upload the syllabus with course name and your name as part of the filename.

[Don't apply last minute and expect immediate approval](#)

A link like [this](#) with only course descriptions is not going to qualify as a syllabus.

If we have to approve a course which will count towards your major credits, we have to have access to the full syllabus and schedule/topics discussed in the course, with a list of readings because this has a direct bearing on the major.

Most instructors or department coordinators are happy to email a syllabus (even a semester or two older ones are fine) for courses when requested. *We will not be able to approve any course without this critical information.*

Ashoka University matches the number of transfer credits with the number of contact hours, subjected to OAA's regulations for the maximum number of credits allowed to be transferred throughout a student's candidature. A typical course at Ashoka is 4 credits (13 weeks x 3 hrs = 39 contact hours). The final decision on whether credits amassed at a summer/semester institution can be transferred to your degree requirements at Ashoka will be of the HoD in consultation with department faculty. *Students should follow this protocol and read the frequently asked questions here first before seeking advice from the HoD during their planning stages.*

Waivers for Prerequisites in Psychology Courses

Currently, the department of psychology only accepts waivers for Statistics and Research Methods I if students have completed “Statistics for Economics” (offered by the department of Economics). Students studying abroad (see above), transferring to Ashoka mid-degree, etc. may ask the Head of Department for permission to bypass certain psychology course requirements in lieu of having completed certain courses in other disciplines.

Waivers for courses can only be used to meet prerequisites (such as by-passing SRM-1 requirements due to the completion of Statistics for Economics, for instance), but the credits of waived courses will not be transferred towards the psychology minor. This implies that if a student receives a waiver for a psychology course - for instance, Statistics and Research Methods I - they cannot receive a major, minor or concentration in psychology by completing only 11, 5, or 3 courses respectively. They must enroll for an additional psychology course to meet their degree requirements - 12 courses for a major, 6 courses for a minor and 4 courses for a concentration. This additional course required to complete minor credits could be either a core or elective course so long as it originates within the Psychology and Cognitive Sciences Department.

The department offers all required courses every semester. Therefore, currently there will be no waivers for any prerequisites for any core course. Prerequisites cannot be converted to co-requisites.

If you have an incomplete grade that is a prerequisite for a core course, please reach out to the UG coordinator with a breakdown of all existing grade components for that course and a tentative date by which the incomplete will be converted to a grade from the course professor.

Such waivers will be inspected and approved on a case by case basis, only if there is a reasonable basis that the student will likely pass the course.

Independent Study Modules

Independent Study Modules (ISMs) are research modules. In general, students can do theoretical research (write review papers) or empirical research (e.g., conducting experiments), or both (e.g., propose a topic, run an experiment, and write results). Different professors have different ways of conducting an ISM. Enrolling for one requires the student to consult the relevant faculty and register one's interest. ISMs are not necessarily pre-defined courses: while some faculty may offer a set of ISMs that align with their research, students may also propose novel ISMs to a faculty member. The decision to enroll a student in an ISM is ultimately that of the faculty member conducting the ISM.

Only three ISM courses of (4x3=12 credits)can be taken by each student during their four-year UG Psychology and Cognitive Sciences program. In 4th year students can earn 8 credits worth of Advanced ISMs that ideally build upon past research experience to the satisfaction of the faculty with whom you take it. There will be no relaxation on the maximum number of two advanced ISMs In cases, where more than two advanced ISMs are undertaken by a student, only two will reflect on the transcript.

Because an ISM may be a research module, it will help students gain research experience. Research experience is very important if you want to go on to a Masters/PhD degree. But even if students do not want to do this, and they are just simply curious at how knowledge is produced, or want to try their hands at producing new knowledge instead of absorbing knowledge in a classroom, doing an ISM is a useful experience. In some sense, every theory that students know now stems from a research idea, which then turns into an exercise to find empirical evidence to prove/disprove the hypothesis.

Undergraduate Capstone Thesis

An honours thesis is a capstone course where students will complete a piece of original scholarly work that contributes substantially to the knowledge and/or application of the discipline. Doing a thesis requires a substantial amount of commitment and time management skills. The workload is spread over two semesters, comprising one 4-credit and one 8-credit courses, PSY-CP-4997 Honours Research Seminar in the monsoon and PSY-CP-4998 Honours Thesis in the spring. **It is not possible to do PSY-CP-4998 without completing PSY-CP-4997.** It is, however, possible to exit the thesis “halfway”. That is, students have the option to not continue with PSY-CP-4998 after they have completed PSY-CP-4997 at the end of the Monsoon. In some cases, they may be advised not to continue with PSY-CP-4998. In either case, students who do not continue with PSY-CP-4998 have the option to do an (advanced) independent study module.

Eligibility

The honors program is typically in the same field as the major subject of the student, hence the student must fulfill the OAA’s requirements of the major. A minimum GPA of 3.5 is required.

Composition of the thesis committee

Your thesis committee consists of two faculty members. One of them is your advisor; you should choose the second member (second reader) in consultation with your advisor. The role your second reader plays should ideally be discussed with them, as well as with your primary advisor, before confirming your second reader.

Grading

PSY-CP-4997:

Advisors’ assessment of your peer review = 10%

Advisors’s assessment of student’s research progress = 30%

Advisor’s assessment of student’s research proposal = 30%

Second reader’s assessment of student’s research proposal = 30%

PSY-CP-4998*:

Advisor’s assessment = 30%

Advisor’s assessment of student’s research proposal = 35%

Second reader’s assessment of student’s research proposal = 35%

**Note:* Grades are not dependent on the statistical significance of your findings.

Timelines

Time	Task
UG3 Spring	Begin planning the undergraduate thesis. Start thinking about their research projects and ideas now, if not earlier. Discuss ideas with prospective advisors. Confirm your thesis advisor as soon as possible.

Summer between UG3 & UG4	Plan the thesis committee together with your advisor. Start focused reading geared towards developing the bibliography for their research work in collaboration with your advisor.
UG4 Monsoon Week 1	Monsoon UG4: Psych 4997 (Honours Research Seminar) Register for PSY 4997 with OAA Start planning and conducting research, collecting preliminary data Start working on the IRB application.
UG4 Monsoon Week 2	Finalize a thesis committee. Start working with the faculty advisor towards a thesis proposal document
UG4 Monsoon Week 3 Friday	Submit a first draft to your advisor with Introduction (background, hypothesis, research questions and rationale), Methods, and any supporting preliminary data. First draft must be written in APA style (6 th edition).
UG4 Monsoon Week 6 Sunday	If you are doing research with human subjects, file an IRB application online at the earliest after monsoon semester starts. Note that the approval time depends on the complexities of the ethical issues involved. Visit https://www.ashoka.edu.in/page/institution-review-board-39 for more details. Submit a final draft of the thesis proposal document to your advisor and committee member. Students who fail to submit by Week 6 Sunday will drop a grade.
UG4 Monsoon Week 7	You will also receive one of your peer's thesis proposal this week. Your task is to write a professional review of your peer's proposal. Your review may be shared with the peer whom you are reviewing, and as such you may request to be anonymous to the peer.
UG4 Monsoon Week 9 Monday	You will submit the review of your peer's work to your advisor.
UG4 Monsoon Week 9 (i.e., the week when we return from mid-sem break)	Colloquium of presentations of thesis proposals (15 min presentation + 10 min questions). This is open to the entire university and the participation of all intended psych majors is strongly encouraged. Questions may come from the committee members or anyone in the audience. You will receive the committee's feedback on the proposal framework, experimental design, analytic strategy, impact, etc. This colloquium is not graded.
UG4 Monsoon Week 11 Monday	Based on the feedback, you will submit a final proposal to your advisor and committee member. Your research progress will be evaluated throughout the semester.
Between Monsoon Week 12 and Spring Week 10: Data collection ***Note that in some fields, multiple studies are expected. Check with your advisor.***	

UG4 Spring Week 10	Spring UG4: PSY 4998 Register for PSY 4998 with OAA, if you haven't already done so. You should complete your data collection and analysis by this time, and submit a first draft of their final thesis. Note that writing a quality draft takes a long time, often with repeated revisions. Plan ahead.
UG4 Spring Week 12 Friday	Once your advisor provides feedback on this initial draft, you should revise your thesis and submit a second draft to all members of your thesis committee. This is the draft the committee will examine during the defense. This draft will not be graded but will help your committee members give better comments. Hence aim to submit a quality draft.
UG4 Spring Week 13 (date to be decided)	Thesis Defence Colloquium (approx. 30-40 mins; duration to be confirmed when the date approaches). This is open to the entire university and the participation of all intended psych majors. Questions may come from the committee members or anyone in the audience. Your committee members will give you feedback on the content and writing of the thesis.
UG4 Spring Week 14, Wednesday	Thesis Submission: Revise your thesis based on feedback from your committee. Note that a thesis is not merely the proposal you wrote last semester plus whatever work you have done this semester. Often you will need to substantially overhaul what you wrote in your proposal and re-conceptualize many issues. Hence leave enough time (about 1 month) to write and edit your work. Submit the following: One hard-bound thesis meant for the library's archive; Two soft-bound copies meant for grading by your committee members; A digital softcopy. You may wish to print additional hard- or soft-bound copies for your keepsake. You will drop a full letter grade for every day you submit late. Your committee members have a very tight timeline to submit grades to the OAA before your convocation and will hence appreciate your timeliness.
Congratulations on successfully completing a significant piece of scholarly work. Celebrate your achievements!	

Undergraduate Teaching Assistantships

1. Applications for Teaching Assistantships (TA) are only open to third and fourth-year students.
2. A UG student will earn 2 academic credits from each TAship.
3. A UG student can take up to **two** TAships in their fourth year, if they have not exhausted those in their third year.
4. A maximum of **two** UGTAships (2 credits each) can count towards the Major, if these credits have not been utilized towards the Major in third year.*

If UGTAships are done before Monsoon 2025 semester, all previous rules will be applied (i.e., a student earns 4 credits from 1 UGTAship, which will count towards the major).

Frequently Asked Questions:

Q. Is the major for psychology at Ashoka considered a B.Sc. or B.A. degree?

A. For the batch of UG2022 onwards, students will be receiving a B.Sc. degree.

Q. Can SRM-I be waived off if I have done an equivalent statistics course from another department?

A. Yes, completing the course **Statistics for Economics** offered by the **Economics Department** is sufficient to waive off SRM-I (but not SRM-II). No other course

Q. I'm a first year prospective psychology major. Do I need to take SRM 1 along with Intro to Psychology in my second semester?

A. If one wants to be able to access all the core courses in one's third semester without further barriers, one needs to take both these courses. However, one can always do them in the third semester, and most core courses in the fourth, and have the whole third year for finishing cores and taking electives - this makes scheduling harder, but it is not impossible - so do not panic if you don't do these courses in the second semester - there is enough wiggle room for being one semester behind, but not more.

Q. Can I take X course despite not meeting prerequisites?

A. The prerequisites are there to ensure you won't have difficulty following the material. Students can get waivers by seeking permission from the instructor of the course, but often students who get waivers later find the course relatively more difficult.

Q. Would it be possible to increase the course-cap for X course?

A. This is entirely the call of the faculty who offer these electives subject to the approval from the HoD and availability of a class-room to accommodate a large class. If interest in a course vastly exceeds the cap, we can consider offering an extra section. For this, the N category in the student tracker needs to exceed our planned sections, so this is where you should indicate interest or need to take a course long before the semester in which you plan to take it.

Q. Are electives part of the Psychology major?

- A. Yes, elective courses are required:
- 20 credits of electives for the 3-year program.
 - 40 credits of electives (3000 level or above) for the 4-year program.

Q. Can cross-listed courses count toward the major?

- A. Yes, cross-listed courses are allowed, but limitations apply:
- Maximum of 2 cross-listed courses for the 3-year program.
 - Up to 1 cross-listed elective in the 4th year of the 4-year program.

Q. How many internship credits can count toward the overall degree?

- A. A maximum of 1 internship (i.e., 2 credits) can count toward the overall undergraduate degree, outside of the Psychology major.

Q. What are the requirements for a Psychology minor?

- A. Students must complete 6 courses (24 credits), including:
- Mandatory courses: Introduction to Psychology, Statistics and Research Methods I & II.
 - Two courses from specified groups (A and B).
 - Additional course from Group A or Group B OR One PSY elective

Q. What are the requirements for a Psychology concentration?

- A. Students must complete 4 courses (16 credits), including:
- Mandatory courses: Introduction to Psychology and Statistics and Research Methods I.
 - Two courses from specified groups (A and B).

Q. Are ISMs allowed for the Psychology concentration?

- A. No, ISM courses are not allowed for concentration in psychology..

Q. Are 4000-level ISM courses allowed in the 4th year?

- A. Yes, up to two 4000-level advanced ISMs are allowed in the 4th year (one per semester), provided the student has not taken any ISM earlier.

Q. Could Professor Y's grading rubric/grade boundaries/course policy for course X please be revisited by the department?

- A. Any course-specific information is best sought from the instructor, and the department does not intervene to their autonomy. You can contact the department head only if the syllabus promised something that was contradicted in practice.

Q. Can X course be rescheduled?

- A. The OAA does not permit rescheduling of courses after pre-registration begins. Requests for rescheduling may constitute a preference of a minority of students, and so there is no responsible way to respond to these requests. Before every semester we circulate a form to assess interest in courses.

Q. Can X course offered by Y department be cross listed by Psychology?

- A. The process for this is for the faculty offering X course to send the course syllabus to the Head of the Psychology department as well as any faculty who teaches an area of psychology adjacent to or similar to the material covered by course X. If the Psychology department finds the course to be methodologically in line with the scientific approach of the department and relevant to the study of behaviour, we could decide to cross-list it and give it a Psychology course code.

Q. How many cross-listed courses one can do out of the 13 courses required for the Psychology major in 3 years or the 18 courses required for a 4 year Psychology major?

A. There is no hard limit on the number of courses originating from Psychology department that are cross-listed with other departments (e.g. Introduction to Neuroscience cross-listed with Biology), but there is a limit of 3 on courses that are primarily offered by other departments and are rooted in other disciplines for a four-year degree and 2 on courses offered by other departments for a 3-year degree.

Q. I haven't done science since the 9th grade, and I am wondering how will I cope with such a Biology heavy course as Intro to Neuroscience? Is the course designed for beginners in science? What is the level of difficulty of the course?

A. The course assumes no prior knowledge of biology at all, so you should be fine. It ramps up from there and the learning curve is steep, but Bittu has taught this for years to students with no bio background and the course involves zero jargon.

Q. Since Course X is cross-listed between two departments, will taking them count towards both a major in one department and a minor in another?

A. - Dept A xxxx/ Dept B yyyy

Department A is the parent department

Department B is the child department

So the course will be considered as a cross-list in your trajectory if you want it to be counted towards department B, because it is being offered by department A. For any course to be cross-listed, there must be written approval of all HODs of the concerned departments.

For eg-

PSY 3063/ ECO 3063

PSY is the parent department

ECO is the child department

So if you want the course to count towards PSY, it won't be considered a cross-list but if you want it to count towards ECO, then it will reflect as a cross-list course in your trajectory.

What if you want it to count towards both?

- If Dept A is your major and Dept B is your minor/concentration, and you want a cross-listed course to count towards both departments, it can be counted for both departments. BUT this does NOT mean that you now have to do one less course to fulfill your graduation requirements. Because credit requirements for declared credentials (major/minor/concentrations) are SEPARATE from credit requirements of degree (overall graduation requirements).

Q. What ISMs/Advanced Independent Study Modules (ISMs) are being offered in (X) semester?

A. ISMs/Advanced ISMs are not a predefined set and are not typically advertised as courses - one applies by either joining any courses the professor has defined on the AMS, or by writing to ask about a proposed ISM to the professor one wants to work with - one can either ask them what ISMs they have planned, or one can propose a new ISM on any topic.

Q. What is the total number of Independent Study Modules (ISMs) that I can do such that they count towards my major?

A. In the first place, ISM credits count towards electives, without any exception. A total of 8 credits worth of maximum two ISMs can be taken by a student in their 3 years of the UG degree, as ISM1 and ISM2. In your fourth year, you can take at most two Advanced ISMs, one in each semester, provided that you have not taken any ISM earlier. These must build on your experience to the satisfaction of the faculty with whom you take it.

Q. I want to understand the procedure to sign up for a thesis in my fourth year. Do we email professors individually or will a google sheet be floated?

Registration for the Capstone Thesis happens on the AMS after consultation with a faculty member who will act as thesis advisor. The department's thesis coordinator will email incoming thesis students just prior to the monsoon semester of their fourth year about the opportunity to apply for a thesis, and you will also need to fill out that form.

Q. I want to understand the procedure to apply as a TA for the coming semester. Do we email professors individually or will a google sheet be floated like last time?

A. The department's TA/TF coordinator sends out an email to fourth and third-year students soliciting interest in TAing courses prior to each semester. You can also write to individual professors whom you wish to TA for, to express your interest in being selected by them during the application process. Professors may have additional application procedures that will be communicated with the student body separately.

Q. I am interested in doing a TAship/writing a thesis although I'm not in my fourth year as yet.

A. Applications for TAships and the Capstone Thesis are only open to fourth-year students. The procedure for applying has been specified above. Third years generally cannot TA and faculty make an exception in only rare cases - we do not encourage this practice. If students will not return for a 4th year and want teaching experience for credit, they can write to the faculty they wish to TA for, and if that faculty has not found 4th year students matching their requirements, they can make an exception. Third year students can not do a thesis, but you can do ISMs and you can always prepare to do research with a faculty member with or without academic credit, starting as early as your first year.

Q. Can a visiting faculty member be a thesis advisor for a prospective fourth year student?

In general, a visiting faculty member cannot be a thesis advisor. The student will have to find a permanent faculty who is willing to be their primary advisor and the visiting faculty can be an advisor only alongside the permanent faculty. In special cases, if a student wants to do a thesis with a visiting faculty it will only be allowed if said faculty is there for the whole academic year. Such accommodations can only be made with the approval from HoD and OAA on a case to case basis.

Q. Is a thesis/ advanced ISM/TAship compulsory for 4th year students?

A. It is not compulsory. It is only compulsory to have completed 72 credits in Psychology for students doing a degree without research and 84 credits in Psychology for students doing a degree with research, alongside the overall credit requirements specified by the OAA.

Q. The handbook mentions that students need to complete 4 upper-level electives for psychology and cognitive sciences Major, but we can only take 2 ISMs and 1 TAship during the year. If no other 4000 level electives are offered, do 3000 level courses also count as upper-level electives?

A. 3000 level electives count towards the 4 year major

Q. I do not understand how the university's grading will translate to my post-grad applications. Does the psychology department write a letter to explain how our grades compare to the scale used by another country? Also, will the psych department somehow explain what the grades really mean, as each course is graded differently?

A. Ashoka does provide letters explaining our transcript. Graduate schools know they get grades from a variety of courses and teaching and grading styles from different liberal arts universities. This is why other things that directly convey student quality like research publications, essays, SOPs etc. matter so much in graduate school applications - they directly convey your skills to the reader, and letters of recommendation also convey a sense of your work ethic.

Q. Who should I contact in case I have further questions?

You can check if your question has already been answered on this sheet:

[Psychology FAQs \(Responses\)](#)

If not you can:

- Fill out the FAQ form: <https://forms.gle/Fan15RQKaybbrs6u8>
- Reach out to the Psychology Representatives at psy.rep@ashoka.edu.in
- Reach out to the UG coordinator at cogpsy.ug@ashoka.edu.in
- Reach out to the HoD at hod.psy@ashoka.edu.in